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A LONGITUDINAL EXAMINATION OF LIFESTYLES*

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ABSTRACT. Defined as the distinctive behavioral expression of a characteristic pattern of values and beliefs, lifestyle is operationalized in terms of a recognizable set of personal construct ratings of everyday activities. A survey, with a follow-up questionnaire seven years after the original study, of the personal projects and subjective well-being of 103 Canadians is reported. Replicating previous work (Horley *et al.*, 1988, *Social Indicators Research*), three general lifestyle types are found. The three lifestyles are labelled provisionally relaxed, pressured, and self-improvement. Although the three lifestyles were represented in the data, about 40% of the respondents were classified on a different lifestyle profile, indicating a moderate degree of lifestyle change.

Three lifestyles are found among those reporting high well-being, and these types bear some resemblance to previous findings. The three lifestyles are labelled individualistic hedonist, self-possessed promethean, and generalist. Sex differences are found in that women are assigned to the generalist lifestyle more than men. In contrast to the original research, men are assigned to a hedonist lifestyle more than women.

Since the sociologist Weber (1922/1968) first used the term “style of life”, and the psychologist Adler (1927) adapted the notion to his particular view of human functioning, social scientists have been concerned with lifestyles. It appears fair to state, however, that the formal and systematic study of lifestyle by social scientists has kept pace neither with public use of the term (Horley *et al.*, 1988) nor with demands for further investigation (e.g., Singer, 1982). This lagging research effort is lamentable because of the potential benefits to a number of areas of inquiry within the social sciences. The social indicators field is one such area.

Lifestyle and life quality are not interchangeable terms (Singer, 1982), but this raises the question of the preferred definition of lifestyle. A brief conceptual examination is demanded here (for more extensive discussions of the concept, see Mitchell, 1983, and Sobel, 1981).

Both pioneers in the use of the term, Weber and Adler, differed in their uses of lifestyle, as one might anticipate given their contrasting theories and disciplinary allegiances. Weber (1922/1968) saw lifestyle in terms of the source and size of income, as well as other socio-

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economic characteristics, and he described how social prestige rests primarily on lifestyle. Adler (1927), on the other hand, defined lifestyle as a unique pattern of behaviors and habits by which an individual strives for superiority. A number of researchers have followed the Weberian (see Zablocki and Kanter, 1976) and Adlerian (e.g., Thorne, 1975) views. The research tends to divide along disciplinary lines.

One investigator who followed Weber, although none too closely, is Sobel (1981). His book, *Lifestyle and Social Structure*, is perhaps the most thorough and scholarly study of lifestyle to date, combining conceptual and empirical analyses. Sobel examined the relationship between numerous variables (e.g., income) and lifestyle variables (e.g., expenditure on housing); and, among other results, he found that family size affects lifestyle by constraining the disposition of family income. Lifestyle was defined as any distinctive mode of living recognizable by observable behavior, but the focus was on consumptive behavior.

Sobel appears correct to examine observable, intentional activity, but he appears overly restrictive to focus on consumptive activity, which may help to explain his rather banal results. Restriction to consumptive behavior is especially troublesome when "nontangibles", such as values and attitudes, are dismissed as irrelevant to the study of lifestyles (Sobel, 1981). This runs counter to many approaches, including sociological work (e.g., Mitchell, 1983), and it conflicts with common everyday usage (Grove, 1976). An acceptable definition of lifestyle should incorporate both intentional behavior or purposive activity, including such behaviors as leisure and sleep (Veenhoven, 1984), and values (Kamler, 1984)¹. Consideration of these points has led to the definition of lifestyle as the distinctive behavioral expression of a characteristic pattern of values and beliefs (Horley *et al.*, 1988).

Although part of the reason for the lack of attention to lifestyles may be due to definitional imprecision, there appears to be a methodological impediment to progress as well. How can purposive activity expressive of underlying values and beliefs be assessed? Questionnaires about values (e.g., Mitchell, 1984), behavioral observation, or unobtrusive searches of refuse containers for liquor bottles seem inadequate on their own. One recent methodological development, personal projects analysis (PPA; Little, 1972, 1983), allows assessment of both purposive activity and values. Little (1987) argued cogently that concern with

purposive activity is, or should be the focus of a variety of areas within psychology, if not all of the social sciences, and a personal projects framework permits assessment of purposive activity. Lifestyle-relevant behavior might be somewhat habitual², but much of it involves conscious choice, and choice implies purpose, or “goal-directedness”. Such dynamism cannot be expressed easily in traditional questionnaire results or garbage heaps, but it might be expressed by personal statements of current activities. Such an examination also provides ecologically valid assessment in that the social and physical environmental context of activity is taken into account (Little, 1983, 1987).

The personal project, or an interrelated sequence of actions intended to attain or to maintain a state of affairs foreseen by an individual, is the basis of PPA. Personal projects have been elicited and examined using a number of techniques, but most notably the personal project matrix (PPM; see Little, 1983, or Palys and Little, 1983). The PPM is a matrix or grid technique that can be seen as one manifestation of Kelly's (1955) repertory grid methodology (Horley, 1988). The assessment of values in PPA can be conducted using the PPM or a number of other techniques, including Little's (1983) “value-laddering” technique. In contrast to Palys and Little (1983), I (Horley, 1988) argued that project dimensions (see Little, 1983) — one set of analytic units used by PPM respondents to examine their own personal projects — are not fundamentally different from personal constructs (Kelly, 1955). If personal constructs can be understood in terms of values and beliefs (Horley, *in press*), so too can project dimensions, albeit with some care when provided dimensions or constructs are used. A truly idiographic approach (e.g., Kelly, 1955) would allow respondents to provide their own “terms of reference”, or the personal values and beliefs that they use to make sense of their own experience — experience which includes their own projects. For a brief discussion of this issue of elicited versus provided dimensions in the context of personal construct theory, see Adams-Webber (1979).

Accepting the need for both adequate conceptual and methodological foundations, lifestyle factors may help to explain subjective well-being (SWB). Diener (1984), Veenhoven (1984), and others have pointed this out, at the same time noting that there have been few systematic studies of lifestyles and SWB. Veenhoven (1984) reviewed a

number of studies, and he concluded that leisure activities do appear related to SWB. There are now more studies that have looked at more general lifestyle types in attempts to relate lifestyle factors to SWB. Brinkerhoff and Jacob (1986), for example, investigated the relationship between SWB and values among individuals living an alternative, smallholding lifestyle, and they found that the smallholding "lifestyle is rationalized by a complex value system that emphasizes simple living and harmony with the natural environment" (p. 171). One report of two lifestyle studies using PPA was provided by Horley *et al.* (1988).

Horley *et al.* (1988) used the PPM to examine the activities and values of a number of Canadians. Analysis of the PPA data for the two groups revealed three overall lifestyle patterns, and these were tentatively labelled pressured, relaxed, and wishful-thinking lifestyles³. When only those individuals from a university group reporting high SWB were included in the analysis, four lifestyles described as hedonistic, adventurous, individualistic, and promethean (a term borrowed from Morris, 1956, to denote an active and involved life) were found. Examination of the personal projects of selected individuals supported these labels. In addition, analysis of various demographic and socio-economic variables revealed age and sex differences. Younger individuals tended to report hedonistic and adventurous lifestyles, in contrast to older individuals' promethean proclivities. Women, more than men, tended to be assigned to the hedonistic lifestyle.

The research project reported in the first study of Horley *et al.* (1988) was only the first panel of a longitudinal examination of everyday activities and SWB (see also Horley and Little, 1985, and Horley and Lavery, in press). Selected research participants were surveyed seven years after the original survey. Changes in lifestyle were examined in this work. It was expected that lifestyle would remain relatively constant, although this expectation was tempered by the exploratory nature of the research. The personal projects of individuals and the movement of individuals between lifestyles were also concerns of the research. As Zablocki and Kanter (1976) suggested, research into lifestyles should be addressed to "the process of transition of individuals among lifestyles with the hope of discovering patterns of lifestyle mobility and characteristic life-style careers" (p. 294). Thus, lifestyle shifts or changes were examined in this follow-up.

METHOD

Participants

Over 1000 respondents were recruited on a volunteer basis in St. Catharines, a largely middle-class urban centre in Ontario, Canada, to participate in a study of personal projects. A random selection of these participants ($n = 298$) were mailed a survey booklet roughly seven years after the first interview, and 136 returned the survey. A listwise deletion of cases (i.e., cases were eliminated when inconsistent data between the two survey sessions were provided) resulted in a further reduction of 33 respondents. The panel is younger ($\bar{x} = 32.3$ years) than the entire sample ($\bar{x} = 36.4$ years), and this is reflected in a larger percentage of single people and students in the panel versus the entire sample. On the whole, however, the panel and the entire sample are quite similar; and both are similar to Atkinson's (1982) representative, national sample of Canadians (for more demographic detail, see Horley and Lavery, in press).

Measures

Among other questionnaires, all 103 respondents completed a PPM identical to the first survey. Respondents were asked to list as many current personal projects as they could in 10 minutes. They were then asked to rate each of the activities, to a maximum of 10, on the PPM from zero to 10 on each of the 16 provided dimensions or constructs. These dimensions were: (1) importance, or the current importance of the project; (2) enjoyment, or the current enjoyment of the project; (3) difficulty, or how difficult the project seems to be; (4) visibility, or how aware relevant others are of the project; (5) control, or the sense of personal control over the project; (6) initiation, or the sense of personal responsibility for beginning the project; (7) stress, or the stress resulting from the project; (8) time adequacy, or the perception that the amount of time spent on the project is sufficient; (9) outcome, or the perception that the project will terminate successfully; (10) self-identity, or the personal typicality of the project; (11) others' views of importance, or how important to the respondent that other people see the project; (12) value congruency, or the extent to which a project is consistent with

personal values; (13) positive impact, or the extent to which a project facilitates other projects; (14) negative impact, or the extent to which a project hinders other projects; (15) progress, or the rating of the success of the project to date; (16) challenge, or the extent to which the project is demanding.

A total of three global SWB measures included in the survey will be considered for the purposes of the present analysis (for definitions, see Horley, 1984, and Horley and Little, 1985). An 11-point self-anchoring ladder of life quality (adapted from Cantril, 1965) was used. It included separate ratings of past, present, and future life quality, but only the present rating was employed in the present study. Also included was an 11-point rating of life satisfaction used by Atkinson (1982) and others.

Data analysis

Initially, product-moment correlation coefficients were calculated between respondents' PPM ratings for each of the provided dimensions to yield test-retest coefficients.

Analysis of respondents' mean PPM ratings (averaged across projects) on each of the 16 dimensions was conducted using modal profile analysis. This statistical technique, developed by Skinner (e.g., 1977), exists in the form of a FORTRAN computer program (Skinner and Lei, 1980). Model profile analysis is a clustering or numerical taxonomic technique that groups individuals into "modal profiles" (via their ratings of scores on a set of variables), or a "best" set of types underlying a sample according to the least squares criterion. Variable scores are expressed as *T* scores, or standard scores with a mean of 50 and a standard deviation of 10. Individual respondents are classified (i.e., assigned a profile loading) on the basis of their response resemblance to the vectors of variables' *T* scores. In the present study, the modal profiles were interpreted as types of lifestyle, and each respondent could be seen as exhibiting a particular general lifestyle. Following Skinner (1977), only *T* scores above or below one standard deviation from the mean were considered in the interpretation of the modal profiles. When interpreting the profiles, the personal projects reported by respondents were considered.

SWB level of the respondents was determined by a multiplicative

combination of the three SWB ratings. A mean split of the results produced "high SWB" and "low SWB" groups, and the project data from the high SWB group were subjected to a second profile analysis.

RESULTS

Test-retest results for the PPA dimensions/constructs are presented in Table I. All were positive, and they ranged from $r = 0.01$ (on the initiation dimension) to $r = 0.47$ (on the outcome dimension). The mean r was 0.30.

Comparison of the MPA profiles from the subgroup and larger group (see Horley *et al.*, 1988) revealed a high degree of similarity. The only difference — a reversal of the first two profiles, with an accompanying reversal of the variance explained — is minor yet noteworthy.

The modal profiles from the 103 respondents at Time 2 can be found in Table II. These lifestyle types are very similar to the first set (r 's from 0.74 to 0.92). Again, the great majority of the explained variance is accounted for by the first profile, a lifestyle reflecting ease and success of activity. The second and third profiles in the set are the

TABLE I
PPA test-retest results ($n = 103$)

Project dimension	Time 1 $\bar{X}$ (s.d.)	Time 2 $\bar{X}$ (s.d.)	r	p
Importance	7.49(1.26)	7.25(1.22)	0.32	0.001
Enjoyment	6.49(1.30)	6.15(1.38)	0.45	0.001
Difficulty	5.00(1.66)	5.00(1.64)	0.35	0.001
Visibility	5.89(1.75)	5.82(1.70)	0.14	n.s.
Control	7.78(1.06)	7.73(1.27)	0.36	0.001
Initiation	7.90(1.31)	7.79(1.54)	0.01	n.s.
Stress	4.43(1.54)	4.19(1.59)	0.23	0.01
Time adequacy	5.73(1.74)	5.70(1.84)	0.27	0.01
Outcome	7.88(1.13)	7.56(1.23)	0.47	0.001
Self identity	7.35(1.22)	7.14(1.33)	0.22	0.05
Others' view	6.21(1.75)	6.02(1.46)	0.27	0.01
Value congruency	7.66(1.66)	8.05(1.48)	0.31	0.001
Positive impact	6.21(2.14)	6.26(2.18)	0.22	0.05
Negative impact	2.94(2.11)	2.66(1.96)	0.42	0.001
Progress	4.89(1.98)	4.90(1.74)	0.25	0.01
Challenge	6.17(1.66)	5.93(1.66)	0.40	0.001

TABLE II
Lifestyle types from Time 2 ($n = 103$)

Project dimension	Modal profile (T scores)		
	1	2	3
Importance	53	57	57
Enjoyment	54	47	44
Difficulty	<u>35</u>	49	64
Visibility	47	56	45
Control	59	<u>63</u>	46
Initiation	58	<u>65</u>	49
Stress	<u>32</u>	45	58
Time adequacy	58	<u>28</u>	45
Outcome	<u>62</u>	55	46
Self identity	58	50	51
Others' view	51	50	45
Value congruency	59	56	<u>60</u>
Positive impact	52	<u>39</u>	<u>60</u>
Negative impact	<u>29</u>	58	<u>25</u>
Progress	52	<u>31</u>	<u>40</u>
Challenge	41	53	<u>65</u>

reverse of the first, but account for similar amounts of variance. The only noteworthy difference is that low time adequacy at Time 1, a characteristic of the pressured lifestyle, is reflected in the wishful-thinking or self-improvement lifestyle.

This first attempt to examine lifestyles over time shows the stability of the three lifestyle types. It is not the case, however, that total consistency in lifestyle can be inferred from the stability of the lifestyle typology. Examination of the individuals in the current study, a full 40% (41 of 103) shifted profile from Time 1 to Time 2. In other words, these individuals provided construct ratings of projects sufficiently dissimilar so as to lead to a different lifestyle assignment, and this shift is reflected in some low test-retest reliabilities among the project dimensions. There were no discernable patterns in the nature of the lifestyle changes.

The four lifestyles from the high SWB group in the original report (Horley *et al.*, 1988) were not replicated, in general, by the present research (see Table III). Three lifestyle types were found in the present analysis. The first lifestyle, characterized by little hassle (low difficulty, low stress, and low negative impact) and mutual facilitation (high

TABLE III
High SWB lifestyle types from Time 2 ($n = 46$)

Project dimension	Modal profile (T scores)		
	1	2	3
Importance	52	52	<u>63</u>
Enjoyment	54	52	44
Difficulty	<u>37</u>	42	58
Visibility	50	57	41
Control	57	<u>62</u>	58
Initiation	56	<u>63</u>	57
Stress	<u>31</u>	44	55
Time adequacy	49	<u>23</u>	54
Outcome	<u>62</u>	54	48
Self identity	57	49	55
Others' view	54	52	<u>40</u>
Value congruency	59	45	<u>66</u>
Positive impact	<u>60</u>	44	<u>32</u>
Negative impact	<u>27</u>	<u>63</u>	<u>40</u>
Progress	52	<u>40</u>	<u>33</u>
Challenge	44	57	56

outcome and high positive impact), is related to both the hedonistic type ($r(14) = 0.87$, $p < 0.01$) and the individualistic type ($r(14) = 0.67$, $p < 0.01$) from the first study (Horley *et al.*, 1988). This profile, as a combination of individualism and hedonism, might be labelled individualistic hedonism. The most striking feature of respondents' project lists for this type is travel, insofar as nearly all respondents were going on, or planning for at least one exotic vacation.

The second type, characterized by high self-involvement (high control and high initiation) but little interproject facilitation (low time adequacy, low progress, and high negative impact), is related significantly to the promethean type, but marginally so ($r(14) = 0.53$, $p < 0.05$). This profile presents some interpretive difficulties. The term self-possessed promethean is suggested as a provisional descriptor.

Also related to the promethean lifestyle is the third profile ($r(14) = 0.74$, $p < 0.01$), characterized by high importance and value congruency but little integration (low positive impact, low negative impact, low progress, and low others' view of importance). In light of these respondents' projects (which included many home and family-centred activities), the label suggested in addition to promethean was happy

homemaker. An examination of the occupations of individuals assigned to this profile revealed only one homemaker, however. The diversity of the projects of these women and one man, who just made it into this type past the cutoff criterion, was interesting. Perhaps the term generalist best describes this type, although a generalist's projects are not necessarily unrelated.

In contrast to the results of the first report, age was not found to be a significant factor in the SWB lifestyles ($X^2(2) = 1.25$, n.s.). Like the first report, however, sex was found to be a significant factor ($X^2(2) = 7.24$, $p < 0.05$). Women were assigned to the generalist lifestyle more than men, while men were assigned to the hedonist lifestyle more than women.

DISCUSSION

The finding that 40% of the sample were assigned to different lifestyle profiles in Times 1 and 2 might be surprising to some. Since there is no reason to believe in complete stability of lifestyle over the course of life (Zablocki and Kanter, 1976), especially in times of personal or social developmental change, this finding should not be surprising. Given that, when socio-economic status is held constant, the best predictor of lifestyle is stage in the life cycle (Zablocki and Kanter, 1976), and remembering the seven year range of the study, some change would seem inevitable. Lifton (1971) posited a "Protean personality" that is "characterized by constant shifts in identification and belief" (p. 298). The lifestyle of Proteans, according to Lifton, is manifested in sudden and dramatic shifts in interests and activities, but all activities tend to be concerned with a quest for personal meaning and development. Whether or not the 40% of the sample who shifted profile from Time 1 to Time 2 are Protean is questionable, although a possibility. Perhaps the best means of determination is repeated sampling over a longer period of time in order to detect regular or constant shifts in lifestyle. Monitoring of life change would permit more insight into events that might account for such lifestyle shifts.

Interpretation of the relaxed and pressured lifestyles, which have accounted for the overwhelming amount of the explained variance to date (see also Horley *et al.*, 1988), is facilitated by the distinction

between Type *A* and Type *B* behavior patterns (Friedman and Rosenman, 1959). Type *A* behavior — described as an “overt behavior pattern or style of living” characterized by, among other elements, a perception of being under time pressure (Jenkins, 1979) — seems to correspond to the pressured lifestyle; on the other hand, an unhurried Type *B* behavior pattern seems to correspond to the relaxed lifestyle. Indeed, a correspondence is likely given the “grossness” of the Type *A*-Type *B* dichotomy and the omnibus lifestyle profiles reported herein, in contrast to types derived from specific criteria like SWB or depression. This problem of how to cut the lifestyle pie is an important issue facing investigators. If it is accepted that an individual can lead only a single lifestyle at any given time, the choice of a descriptor of the lifestyle is probably dependent upon one’s (changing?) perspective on the behavioral-value dynamic of the target individual. In the context of the present study, the perspective can change somewhat depending on the selection criterion for the profile analysis, and the rub is selecting the most appropriate criterion, the one that will allow the best view of the individuals in the study. It is important to keep in mind that, while some individuals appear in both profile analyses reported herein, they are not being described in terms of two distinct lifestyles. Clearly, the two sets of profiles in Tables II and III are similar. Perhaps the choice of selection criteria is best determined by the research interests of the investigator — and, thus, SWB may be the most appropriate choice for social indicators researchers — but this question remains moot.

In hindsight, the finding that many more relaxed individuals were represented in the subsample than overall group should have been anticipated. If one is feeling pressured by insufficient time for ongoing projects, especially if the projects are going poorly, participation in a lengthy research project is likely the last activity that one would adopt willingly. This selection bias in the longitudinal subsample, while troublesome in terms of generalizability, does shed some light on the characteristics of those who agree to long-term research involvement.

The observed differences between the high SWB profiles from the first report and the high SWB profiles from the present study are not necessarily cause for concern. As mentioned, lifestyles likely change over time, and the path that leads to high SWB at one point in time is perhaps not the path that will always do so. The samples from the

two analyses came from different settings, a university campus and a general urban community, and this factor might help to account for the differences. The significant effect of the first analysis is attributable perhaps to the relative homogeneity of the sample. In a group of relatively young, well educated people, "older" individuals reporting high SWB might have very different means of attaining and maintaining such a state compared to their younger colleagues, and certainly very different means than older non-university individuals. The sex differences observed in both studies also revealed one disjunction: In the first study, women were more often assigned to the hedonistic lifestyle while, in the second study, men were more often assigned to this lifestyle. This finding might be explained as pointing to the ease with which women deal with university life compared to men, or it may reflect the seriousness of university training for men versus women. At any rate, the diversity explanation or the sample difference explanation are just two possibilities among several substantive explanations that are preferable to an artifactual one. Unfortunately, the small numbers in both SWB analyses may have produced unreliable results.

SUMMARY AND CONCLUSIONS

Previous research (Horley *et al.*, 1988) that revealed a set of three general lifestyles among a sample of middle-class Canadian urbanites has been replicated by the present findings. This replication, however, does not indicate invariance of lifestyle choice since 40% of the survey respondents showed different patterns of responses across the two survey occasions. Interestingly, too, the relaxed lifestyle that accounted for a moderate amount of variance in the first study accounted for a majority of variance in the second — a demonstration that only people with a perception of time availability will participate in follow-up research.

Replication of the profiles of those reporting high SWB was much less successful. Some similarity was found, but major differences (e.g., women were assigned to a hedonist lifestyle on the first occasion while men were assigned to a hedonist lifestyle on the second) do exist. Differences between the samples used on the two occasions may help to account for these differences, but the issue concerning the appropriate-

ness of specific criteria (e.g., SWB) for selecting subsamples for analysis remains.

The research to date has shown that the rich, complex data provided by Kelly's (1955) repertory grid, at least when Little's (1983) personal projects are used as elements, are reduceable to an interpretable form using modal profile analysis (see Adams-Webber, 1979, for other approaches); however, at least four areas of inquiry remain to be addressed in future research. First, the interpretability of profiles if provided dimensions are changed is questionable; and, specifically, one might wonder whether semantically similar constructs would yield similar sets of lifestyle labels. Second, personal project content of individuals who change lifestyle, as well as those who do not, requires systematic examination. This content analysis of project descriptions might also provide some insights into SWB hitherto unobserved in project ratings or other quantitative ratings (see Wood and Johnson, 1989). Third, examination of factors that account for lifestyle change is required. Life change and/or developmental stage variables, at the very least, should be included in further inquiries to help to explain change in lifestyle patterns. Finally, instead of holding social class constant, respondent samples heterogeneous with respect to class demand examination. Only in this way can the importance of class as a predictor of lifestyle, as well as the relationship between class and other hypothesized predictors (Zablocki and Kanter, 1976), be examined properly.

NOTES

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¹ Unlike Kamler (1984), I make no attempt here to distinguish between "life philosophy" (or personally-derived) values and "life style" (or socially-derived) values. Such a distinction appears artificial.

² Habits are among the "behavioral events" that present problems for PPA. See also Horley (1988).

³ A label suggested in the original report (Horley *et al.*, 1988) was wishful-thinking because of a number of projects expressed as "Plan to . . ." or "Hope to . . .". "Thinking about losing weight" is a fine example provided by one respondent. These projects, however, are not as numerous as perhaps desirable. Instead, because many of the activities of prototypical respondents are concerned with personal improvement (e.g., "Finishing my degree", "Stop nail-biting", "Find a better job"), a more appropriate descriptor of this lifestyle may be self-improvement.

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